

BEFORE

Today's "Polynesians" are linked by language and DNA evidence to two prehistoric peoples.

POLYNESIAN ORIGINS

Polynesians today are descended from a southeast Asian group (probably from modern-day Taiwan), and a group indigenous to Melanesia (near Papua New Guinea). These two peoples gave rise to the Melanesian "Lapita" culture, whose pottery dates back as far as 1600 BCE. In the early centuries CE, these people split into many tribes and explored the South Pacific.

HOW WE KNOW

MOA BIRD

The enormous moa was one of many victims of the Polynesian expansion. These giant, wingless birds, up to 12 ft (3.6 m) tall, were hunted to extinction by Maori settlers of New Zealand. Later European expeditions collected remains for study by scientists such as Richard Owen (1804–92), below.



Polynesian Expansion

By approximately 700 CE, the Polynesians had reached all corners of the South Pacific, spreading across the uninhabited islands of Micronesia and reaching the extreme limits of their exploration and settlement at New Zealand and Easter Island, leading to a diverse range of cultures.

Archaeological evidence for the presence of Polynesian settlers from around 700 CE has been found in places as far flung as Samoa, Hawaii, and New Zealand. The islands, however, never formed a single empire of the type found elsewhere in the world—each group of settlers lived mostly in isolation, occupying territories that ranged in size from a small portion of an island, to a whole group of small islands. For this reason an incredible range of diverse cultures developed across Polynesia, each with its own way of life, customs, and tools. Some built huge stone cities, while others lived in villages on the beach. Contact with other groups among the isolated islanders was rare, while among groups sharing an island, war was frequent.



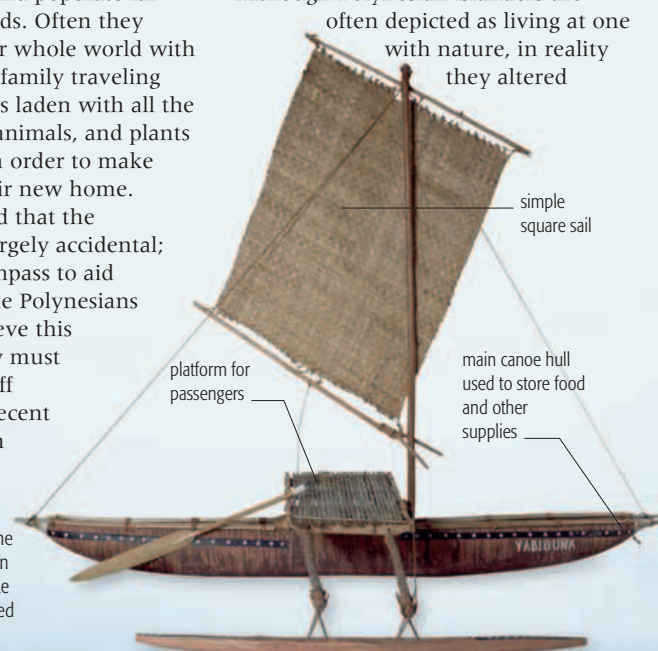
Polynesian pendant

Although the Polynesians did not use metal, they were able to create intricate tools and jewelry, such as this greenstone pendant.

into the unknown and often against the prevailing winds, to reach and populate far-flung islands. Often they brought their whole world with them—an entire family traveling together, their boats laden with all the possessions, tools, animals, and plants they would need in order to make a distant island their new home.

Some have argued that the colonization was largely accidental; without even a compass to aid their navigation, the Polynesians surely did not achieve this intentionally—they must have been blown off course. However, recent studies have shown

that ancient Polynesian methods of navigation using the stars, birds, winds, currents, and tides would have been surprisingly reliable when crossing even the widest gulf of ocean. Some recent explorers have even repeated these epic journeys in replica boats. Although Polynesian islanders are often depicted as living at one with nature, in reality they altered



Double-hulled canoe

The Polynesians explored the ocean more extensively than anyone before in vessels like this. Supplies could be stored in the double hull.

Across the ocean

The Polynesians were great shipbuilders, navigators, and sailors, and probably reached America more than a hundred years before the Vikings. They sailed on long voyages,

887 The number of Moai statues found across Easter Island.

Nearly 400 lie in the quarries where they were carved, but 288 were moved and erected successfully. The remainder were abandoned on roads.

